

Technology in Business

Why digital fluency is no longer optional

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Connect to Prior Knowledge

In Lessons 01 and 02, you set up your professional digital workspace and learned how BUS123 is structured. Now we zoom out to answer a bigger question: *why does any of this matter?* Technology is not a background detail of modern business — it is the infrastructure that business runs on. This lesson builds the conceptual foundation for everything that follows: understanding where technology fits in professional life, what digital fluency actually means, and why the habits you build now determine how you show up in your first job.

Concept Overview

Technology by the Numbers

A few data points frame the scale of technology in professional environments:

Statistic	Source / Context
1.2 billion Microsoft 365 users monthly	Microsoft — the most widely adopted productivity platform in the world
80% of Fortune 500 run on Microsoft 365	Microsoft enterprise data — the standard for large-organization professional tools
67% of jobs require advanced digital skills	McKinsey Global Institute — beyond basic email and document use

Passive User vs. Professional Operator

There is a meaningful difference between using technology and operating it professionally. Most people are passive users — they use tools as given, with default settings, and look up help every time something goes wrong. A professional operator builds systems, writes formulas, structures data for others, and solves novel problems without guidance.

Passive User	Professional Operator
Types answers into cells	Builds formulas with cell references

Uses default settings	Customizes tools for the task
Accepts data at face value	Questions data sources and accuracy
Searches for help every time	Diagnoses and resolves errors independently
Does the task once manually	Automates repeatable work

Data Fluency: Read, Question, Act

Data fluency is often misunderstood as a purely technical skill. In reality, it is the ability to work with data meaningfully — understanding what it shows, challenging its assumptions, and using it to support decisions. The three-step framework:

Step	What It Means	Example
Read	Understand what a chart or table is actually showing	Sales are up 12% — but vs. which prior period?
Question	Challenge the source, scope, and accuracy of the data	Are returns included? Which channels? What is excluded?
Act	Use the analysis to make or support a business decision	Recommend increasing inventory for top-selling SKUs

■ Most organizations have more data than they know what to do with. The professionals who advance are not the ones who generate the most data — they are the ones who can tell a clear story from it.

AI Tools and Human Judgment

AI tools are reshaping professional workflows — but they are not replacing the need to understand the underlying work. The key distinction is between what AI does well (drafting, suggesting, summarizing) and what still requires human judgment (verifying correctness, applying context, being accountable for decisions). Professionals who understand their tools deeply will always be more valuable than those who rely on AI to produce outputs they cannot explain.

■ The professional who understands Excel deeply will always be more valuable than one who relies on AI to produce outputs they cannot explain. Build the skill first — then use AI to accelerate it.

Key Reference — Technology by Industry

Industry	Case Study Company	Key Technology Uses
Retail	Tidal Goods Co.	POS data, inventory tracking, demand forecasting, markdown analysis
Financial Services	Meridian Advisory Group	Payroll systems, TVM models, loan amortization, tax calculation
Event Planning	Anchor & Oak Events	Breakeven models, cash flow projections, labor scheduling
Healthcare	Harborside Medical Center	Payer mix dashboards, patient data analysis, complex payroll



Check Your Understanding

Answer these 7 questions after reading.

1. Explain the difference between a passive technology user and a professional technology operator. Give one specific example of each behavior in an Excel context.

2. A classmate says: "I already know Excel — I use it for my personal budget." Based on the fluency spectrum, what level does this likely represent, and what would it take to reach Professional Operator level?

3. Choose one of the four BUS123 case study companies and describe two specific ways technology supports its operations. Be specific — name the type of tool or analysis used.

4. Define data fluency in your own words. Then give an example of how the "Question" step of data fluency (read, question, act) would apply to a sales report.

5. What is one skill that AI tools currently do well, and one task where human judgment is still required? Why does the distinction matter for your career?

6. You are interviewing for a marketing coordinator role. The job description mentions Excel and data reporting. Describe two specific BUS123 skills that directly apply to this role.

7. What does it mean for technology to be "the infrastructure business runs on"? Use one statistic from this lesson and one example from a real industry to support your answer.

Key Vocabulary

Digital Fluency

The ability to use technology tools purposefully and professionally — not just operating them, but adapting them to solve specific problems, evaluating their outputs, and integrating them into workflows.

Data Fluency

The ability to read, question, and act on data. Involves understanding what a dataset shows, challenging its assumptions and sources, and using it to support business decisions.

Passive User

Someone who uses technology as given — with default settings, no customization, and without building systems or formulas that scale. Treats results as outputs to type rather than formulas to build.

Professional Operator

A technology user who builds scalable systems, structures data for others, diagnoses and resolves errors independently, and uses tools to solve novel problems without external guidance.

Fluency Spectrum

A five-level framework describing stages of technology proficiency: Basic User, Functional User, Skilled User, Professional Operator, and Expert. BUS123 targets Professional Operator level.

Formula Thinking

The habit of expressing business logic as Excel formulas rather than typed values — so that results update automatically when inputs change and the model remains valid for repeated use.

AI Tool Proficiency

The ability to use AI tools effectively while maintaining judgment about the accuracy and appropriateness of their output. Includes knowing when to trust AI suggestions and when to verify independently.